

Technoparanoia

HAVE YOU EVER QUESTIONED each and every action of yours when you've had a bad day and wanted to figure out where it all stemmed from? It's interesting to see how the chain of causality keeps on going endlessly till you hunt down the ultimate reason behind that absurdly bad day. The thing is, sometimes, you are satisfied by digging a couple of layers deep but sometimes, the digging never stops. You unearth more and more reasons and then the realisation starts to seep in. It appears that it was all purposely geared towards making your day bad. It's as if there was an entity or collection of entities out to get you.

A decade or so ago, this would have been seen as a mental disorder. I'd like to believe it's quite normal these days. As many academics have put it so eloquently, data is the new oil and everyone is out to get it regardless of whether you give your consent or not. However, sometimes your data isn't exactly what they're after. The more devious ones aren't afraid to take it one step ahead and hold your life ransom. After all, you might be willing to sacrifice your precious data, but your life... that's where most people draw the line. It's a common plot device that's often used in dystopian movies. Given the current world events, it would appear that we're all geared towards realising that dystopian future from the movies. No, I'm not talking about the remote future, it's happening now. From simple ransomware that threaten to delete your data, to AI based filtering systems that'll block you out of every single digital service by mistake, to malware sequenced into DNA. Yes, the threats are no longer limited to just digital vectors.

You'd be quick to point out that computers don't make mistakes, instead, it's always the actions of the programmer or operator that trickle down to what we term as a mistake. The term is relative and very much based in culture. An incident that we term as a mistake could be seen by an AI as absolutely normal. Like how an AI tends to develop racial and gender biases when left to learn on its own. That's a big no-no in human speak, but for machines, that's a conclusion arrived upon by methodological pattern analysis. What I'm

trying to convey is that both human elements, and AI-enabled devices can easily act against you. Just watch any live stream from one of the many hacker conferences held each year. It's absolutely mind-boggling. Every year some of the best minds on the planet expose vulnerabilities within objects that were deemed secure and guaranteed to be unhackable.

This makes me wonder, is being paranoid really as bad as it's made out to be? I'd say yesterday's paranoia is simply today's caution. Paranoia, without the negative connotation is simply someone being extra cautious. I'm not discounting the fact that there are individuals who indeed suffer from irrational fears, but after coming across some really disturbing attack vectors, I'm starting to think that technoparanoia is quite reasonable. This month's cover story is all about exploring how existing and upcoming technologies can be used against you. We don't claim to be experts in the field of AI but we're better off than the average joe with regards to being up to date with the latest happenings in the world of technology, and some of the things we dug up were a bit too much, even for us. I don't want to spoil it for you, so I'm going to keep my lips sealed and my eyes peeled.

So, is the answer to all of these threats to simply hole up in the middle of nowhere like our cave-dwelling forefathers used to? Not quite. There's always redundancy, an age old, tried and tested method. It's not a solution to all attack vectors but you'll be better off than those who don't exercise caution. But is that still enough? Perhaps, it's safest to disconnect from everything or perhaps, the cave seems a teensy bit more appealing. What would you do faced with all the information we've shared in the cover story? Disconnect and join me in my cave, or do you have a different approach? I'm all ears. **d**



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